

the country since with an iron hand. The State Peace and Development Council (SPDC), which decides government policy, comprises the top 12 generals but the top two military men—Senior General Than Shwe and his deputy General Maung Aye—take the decisions.

While the arrests have stemmed the protests, the junta is yet to tackle the conditions which gave rise to these protests—the deteriorating living conditions in which the majority of the Myanmar people live. More than 90 per cent of the population lives on less than 300,000 kyat (around Rs 12,000) a year, said Charles Petrie, head of the UN mission in Myanmar. The recent rise in fuel prices—that of petrol doubled while natural gas prices increased by more than 500 per cent—has sent food prices soaring.

The monks, who are usually apolitical, took the lead in the agitation because they are close to the people and understand their hardships. “They know better than anyone what impact the rising fuel and food prices are having on the people at the grassroots,” said Myanmar analyst Aung Naing Oo, who himself lived in a monastery for a while. Monks survive on the daily alms that they collect from the public. They understand that surviving on alms has become harder and harder, especially over the past two years. “What they used to get from four or five houses, now takes more than 30,” he added.

In recent weeks the monks’ marches have clearly turned political. “We want national reconciliation, we want dialogue with the military, we want freedom for Suu Kyi and other political prisoners,” one of the protest leaders shouted through a megaphone at a rally in Yangon. Suu Kyi is currently under house arrest in Yangon, where she has been for more than 12 of the past 18 years. The turning point came when more than two thousand monks marched to her home and she came out to meet them. This was too much for the junta to bear

and they unleashed the troops on the demonstrators.

The international community’s response was immediate. It condemned the brutal crackdown and called for restraint. The European Union and the US already have sanctions in place, including trade and investment bans, and have increased restrictions on the regime. But these have had little effect on the generals who rely heavily for trade and investment on their Asian neighbours, especially China and India. They have also gained tremendous confidence after the recent oil finds in the country.

Events in Myanmar have made

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SEARCH FOR PEACE: (From left) Gambari meets Suu Kyi and Than Shwe

Beijing fear that its most important strategic partner in Asia may crumble and become a threat to regional security. The Chinese have been warning the junta to handle the situation with care. India, which in the past decade has befriended the generals for its own strategic interests, too has cautioned them.

Hopes of a peaceful resolution of

the conflict in Myanmar now rest on the efforts of the UN and the secretary-general’s special envoy Ibrahim Gambari, who recently made an emergency visit to Myanmar. During his trip, he met Suu Kyi twice and also General Than Shwe. No details of his discussions have been made

public. But the international community hopes that his shuttle diplomacy will help evolve a peaceful resolution. He is expected to return next month for talks with both sides again, according to a western diplomat in Yangon.

The regime may now see that a reconciliation—genuine talks with the pro-democracy leaders—is the only acceptable solution they are left with as the demonstrations are only set to grow. Former activists and student leaders from 20 years ago are getting organised behind the scenes. Continued demonstrations may also encourage an open revolt within the army.

Says the independent Chiang Mai-based Myanmar analyst Win Min, “Family members of the soldiers at the grassroots level are suffering from increasing food and fuel prices just like the people demonstrating, even as top-level officers are getting enormously rich. Fearing for their future, junior officers may yet stage a palace coup.”

That is how Than Shwe himself came to power, ousting General Saw Maung in 1992. What is certain is that the monks and the military are pitted against each other—both are 4,00,000-strong in terms of numbers. But the monks are unarmed and the soldiers have the guns. What happens next, when the protest marches resume, will depend entirely on the machinations of one man, Than Shwe—unless he’s removed before that by his own soldiers.

The regime may come to see national reconciliation as the only acceptable solution left.